Praise of the Inconceivable

Acintyastava · Toh 1128 · Derge Tengyur
བསམ་གྱིས་མ་ཁྱབ་པར་བསྟོད་པ

The Praise of the Inconceivable, known in Sanskrit as the Acintyastava and in Tibetan as Samgyi Mikhyappar Töpa, is a philosophical hymn in verse that its colophon attributes to the great master Nāgārjuna. Addressed to the Buddha, it praises him for teaching that whatever arises in dependence on conditions is unborn and empty of essential nature, and it works through the central arguments of the Middle Way: that nothing arises from itself, from another, or from both, that self and other, long and short, and knower and known exist only in mutual dependence, and that all things are like illusions, mirages, echoes, and dreams. It describes ultimate reality as beyond existence and nonexistence and free of the four alternatives, like space and beyond the reach of words, identifies it with dependent arising, emptiness, suchness, and the Tathāgata himself, and distinguishes teachings of provisional meaning from the definitive meaning that phenomena lack essential nature. The hymn closes by dedicating the merit of this praise so that all beings may become equal to the Buddha. It is Toh 1128 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of praises (stotra).

In the language of India: acintastavaṃ
In the language of Tibet: Praise of the Inconceivable

Homage to Mañjuśrī in youthful form.

To the one who declared that dependently arisen things
Are without essential nature,
Whose wisdom is unequaled and inconceivable,
To that incomparable one, I pay homage.

Just as you yourself realized
The selflessness of phenomena in the Great Vehicle,
So, under the power of compassion,
You taught it to those endowed with intelligence.

You declared that what arises
In dependence on conditions is unborn;
It is not born by way of an essential nature,
And therefore you taught that it is empty.

Just as here an echo
Arises in dependence on a sound,
And like an illusion or a mirage,
So too existence comes about.

If illusions and mirages,
Cities of gandharvas, reflections,
And dreams were not produced,
Seeing and the rest would have no example.

Just as those that arise from causes and conditions
Are held to be made,
So, Protector, you declared
All that arises from conditions to be like that.

Whatever the childish may say,
They keep calling things made;
That is like the emptiness of annihilation,
And you have shown it is not in accord with the meaning.

When a made thing is never born,
Then what present thing that has arisen
Could perish and so become the past?
And how could the future depend on it?

No thing is born from itself,
Nor from another, nor from both.
It is not existent, not nonexistent, not both existent and nonexistent;
Then from what could anything else arise?

What is unborn has no intrinsic nature;
So from what could it ever arise?
Since it is established that no thing has intrinsic nature,
Nor does anything arise from another.

If self exists, other exists;
If other exists, self exists.
These are established as mutually dependent,
You declared, like the far shore and the near.

When there is no dependence on anything at all,
Then what could arise in relation to what?
When there is no dependence on long,

How could there be short and the rest?

Just as the number one and the rest do not exist,
So too the past, the future, and the rest,
And the afflictions as well, are just the same;
And what, of themselves, are the true and the false?

If no thing exists of itself,
Then what is there at all?
What is called other
Is not so, if there is no intrinsic nature of its own.

When there is no thing that is other,
Then things have no intrinsic nature.
Then for one who grasps at other things and things,
What vehicle to the goal could there be?

Equal from the very beginning,
By their intrinsic nature passed into nirvāṇa,
And in reality unborn:
Therefore you declared phenomena to be such.

Wise one, you have taught that form and the rest
Are without essential nature:
They are like foam, bubbles, illusions and the like,
Mirages, and plantain trees.

If what the senses perceive
Were real,
The childish would know reality;
Then what would be the use of knowing reality?

You declared that the senses are inanimate,
That they are not valid cognition at all,
That they are indeterminate,
And that they know falsely.

Having understood, truly and just as it is,
Who fails to realize what,
You therefore also declared
That the world is obscured by unknowing.

To say it exists is the view of permanence;
To say it does not exist is the view of annihilation.
Therefore you taught the Dharma
That is free of the two extremes.

Therefore you declared that phenomena
Are free of the four alternatives.
They are not even objects of consciousness;
And like what arises from dreams and magical displays,
Like seeing two moons and the like,
You saw that the arising of beings
Has in reality never arisen.

Just as in a dream one sees
Things arise from causes,
So you hold that the arising of all things,
And their perishing as well, are like that.

Likewise desire and the rest, and suffering,
Saṃsāra, suffering, and total affliction,
The completion of the accumulations, and liberation too,
You declared to be like a dream.

Likewise the born and the unborn,
Coming and going,
And likewise bondage and liberation:
One who holds a duality in wisdom does not know reality.

For what has not been born from anything,
What nirvāṇa could there be?
Since it is like an illusory elephant,
In truth it has been at peace from the very beginning.

Just as you hold an illusory elephant
To be unborn even while it is born,
Likewise all things are born,
Or, in reality, unborn.

Although the countless protectors of the world
Have brought beings beyond measure,
Each one, to nirvāṇa,
Yet no one at all has been freed by them.

Great Sage, because sentient beings
Are not born of themselves,
For that reason you have clearly declared
That no one has been freed by anyone.

Just as a thing made by a magician
Is empty, so likewise
All other made things are empty of any real thing,
You declared; and the same is true of the agent.

The agent too is made by another,
And so becomes something made;
Or else, if it performs its own action,
The absurd consequence is that it is its own agent.

"All of these are mere names":
So you declared, praising it as a secret.
Apart from the expression,
There is nothing to be expressed.

Therefore you declared
That all phenomena are mere conceptual thought,
And you declared that even the thought
That conceives them as empty does not exist.

That which has transcended both entity and non-entity,
And yet in some respect has not transcended them,
In which there is no knowing and no knowable,
Which is neither nonexistent nor existent,
Which is neither one nor many,
Not both, and not anything at all,

Without basis, unmanifest,
Inconceivable, and incomparable,
Which neither arises nor ceases,
Without annihilation and without permanence:
That is like space,
Not the domain of letters or of wisdom.

That is dependent arising,
And that you hold to be empty.
The sacred Dharma too is like that,

And the Tathāgata (the Buddha) is the same as it.

It is held to be reality, the meaning,
Suchness, and substance.
It is true and undeceiving;
Through perfecting it, one is called a buddha.

The buddhas and the basic space of phenomena (dharmadhātu)
Are therefore not different in reality;
And therefore you hold
That oneself and others are equal.

Emptiness is not other than things,
And without it there are no things either.
Therefore you taught that things
Arising in dependence are empty.

What arises from causes and conditions
Is conventional, being under the power of another;
You declared that it is called the dependent (paratantra).
The ultimate is not contrived;
It is also essential nature and intrinsic nature,
Reality, substance, entity, and the existent.

The imagined (parikalpita) thing is utterly nonexistent,
And the dependent does not exist.
To say that the imagined thing exists
Is superimposition, you declared;
To say that what is made, once cut off, does not exist
Is annihilation, you declared.

For one who knows truly there is no annihilation,
And it is taught that there is no permanence either.
Beings are empty of real entity;
Therefore you hold them to be like a mirage.

Just as the water that a thirsty deer longs for
Is neither annihilated nor permanent,
So too all beings
You declared to be without annihilation and without permanence.

For anyone for whom some substance comes into being,
Destruction, such as annihilation, follows;
For him the world comes to have an end,
And also to be without end.

Just as there is a knowable because there is knowing,
And knowing because there is a knowable,
When one realizes that both are unborn,
What then exists?

Thus the supreme physician,
Having clearly taught the examples of illusion and the rest,
Taught the sacred Dharma
That puts a stop to all views.

The teaching of the absence of essential nature
Is the true and supreme one;
For those seized by the demon of things,
It is the unsurpassed cure.

Therefore, as one who performs the sacrifice of the Dharma,
Through the stages of that sacrifice, ceaselessly,
You offer up the three worlds as a fire offering.

Cutting through the terror of grasping at things,
And terrifying those deer, the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas),
The wondrous lion's roar of selflessness:
That is what you proclaimed.

You have beaten the great drum of the Dharma,
Of emptiness, most profound;
You have blown the conch of the Dharma,
Loudly resounding with the absence of essential nature.

You have proclaimed the substance of the Dharma,
The nectar of the buddhas' teaching,
And you have also taught that the essential nature
Of all phenomena is the definitive meaning.

Whatever you taught of arising, cessation, and the rest,
And of sentient beings, a soul, and the rest,
That, O Protector, you taught
As provisional meaning, on the conventional level.

You who have yourself reached the far shore
Of the ocean of the perfection of wisdom,
Rich in the jewels of merit and good qualities,
Protector, you have gone to the far shore of good qualities.

By whatever merit I have gained
In thus praising the incomparable, inconceivable
Protector of beings,
May beings become equal to you.

This completes the Praise of the Inconceivable, composed by the venerable great master Nāgārjuna.

Translator's Notes

• In the third verse the Tibetan reads nga bo nyid, evidently a slip for ngo bo nyid, "essential nature," and it is translated so. In the ninth verse the Tibetan reads yod yin, "is existent," which breaks the series of negations; it is translated as the evident yod min, "not existent." The four alternatives are existence, nonexistence, both, and neither. The seventh and fifteenth verses are compressed and their renderings are tentative; "vehicle to the goal" renders don gyi theg pa, whose sense here is uncertain.
• The line rendered "So you declared, praising it as a secret" is obscure in the Tibetan (gsang ni bstod de gsungs), and its sense is uncertain. The Tibetan says that the dependent "does not exist" (yod ma lags), although the lines that follow, which call it annihilation to say that what is made no longer exists, seem to expect "exists"; it is translated as written. The imagined, the dependent, and the ultimate here are the three natures, treated in a Middle Way sense.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.